



OUTBOUND

TRAVEL PLANNING • EST. 2026

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THE PHILIPPINES GUIDE

A practical guide to planning a better trip

2026 EDITION

OUTBOUND.

Travel planning, rethought.



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01 — THE PHILIPPINES, DONE PROPERLY

The Philippines is not one destination. It is an enormous collection of islands, beaches, cities, mountains and remote communities spread across a huge area. That is what makes it so good — and exactly what makes it so easy to plan badly. You can look at a map and see **Manila, Palawan, Cebu, Bohol, Siargao, Boracay, Coron and El Nido** sitting within the same country. The temptation is to put all of them into one itinerary.

Don't.



The Philippines rewards travellers who understand that **transport is part of the trip**. A destination may look close on a map but require a flight, airport transfer, ferry, waiting time and another road journey. Add enough of those connections together and suddenly half of your holiday has disappeared.

The best first-time Philippines trips are therefore built around **a small number of islands and experiences**. Palawan gives you some of the country's most dramatic limestone scenery, lagoons and island-hopping. Cebu provides a useful base for waterfalls, diving and access to nearby islands. Bohol combines beaches, countryside, wildlife and the famous Chocolate Hills. Siargao is about surfing, tropical island life and a more relaxed atmosphere. Boracay is the easy beach holiday: beautiful sand, restaurants, nightlife and excellent infrastructure. Manila is the country's huge urban gateway and can be worth experiencing, but it doesn't need to dominate a first trip.

The most important decision is therefore:

What kind of Philippines trip do you actually want? If you want the classic postcard experience, build around **Palawan**. If you want diving and adventure, look at **Cebu, Coron or Apo Island**. If you want surfing and island culture, choose **Siargao**. If you want an easy beach holiday, choose **Boracay**. If you want a mixture of beaches, countryside and culture, **Bohol** is a strong option. And if you want all of them, you need considerably more time than most first-time visitors realise. A seven-day trip should usually focus on one major island or two closely connected destinations. Ten days gives you enough time for two or three major bases. Two weeks is where a classic Philippines route becomes much more realistic. Three weeks allows you to combine Palawan with another major region without every other day becoming a travel day.

The Philippines is also different from Thailand or Vietnam because **ferries and domestic flights matter much more to the route**. You should therefore think about transport before booking every hotel.

A great itinerary might be:

Manila → El Nido → Coron.

Another:

Cebu → Bohol → Siargao.

Another:

Manila → Boracay → Cebu.

Another:

Cebu → Bohol → Siargao.

There is no single best route. There is only the route that gives you the experiences you actually want.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't count islands. Count the experiences that make the journey worthwhile. The Philippines is at its best when you allow yourself to stop moving.

02 — BEFORE YOU GO

The Philippines is straightforward to travel through once you understand its geography, but there are several things worth planning before you arrive.



WHEN TO GO

The Philippines has a tropical climate, but conditions vary significantly between regions. The generally drier period is commonly around **December to May**, while the wetter period is broadly around June to November. That is only a starting point.

Different islands can experience different weather patterns, and tropical storms can affect travel. If your itinerary relies heavily on ferries, diving, island-hopping or other outdoor activities, weather deserves particular attention.

The best time for your trip therefore depends on **where you're going**, not simply the month you're travelling.

TYPHOONS

The Philippines is exposed to tropical storms and typhoons, particularly during the wetter part of the year. This doesn't mean you cannot travel during those months. It does mean you should avoid building an itinerary where a single cancelled ferry or flight destroys the rest of the holiday.

Leave flexibility around important connections. If you're travelling during a period with a higher risk of storms, check local weather conditions before moving between islands.

ENTRY REQUIREMENTS

Entry requirements depend on your nationality and can change.

Check the current requirements with the **Philippine Bureau of Immigration or the Philippine Embassy relevant to your passport** before travelling. Don't rely on an old travel blog or a social-media post. Also check whether any electronic arrival or customs declaration is required for your journey.

MONEY

The local currency is the **Philippine peso (PHP)**. Cards are increasingly accepted in hotels, larger restaurants and developed tourist areas, but cash remains important. This becomes particularly obvious when travelling to smaller islands. ATMs may be limited, unavailable or unreliable outside major towns. Carry enough cash for your accommodation, transport and activities before travelling somewhere remote.

TRANSPORT

Transport is the single biggest factor in Philippines itinerary planning. Domestic flights connect the major islands. Ferries connect many of the most popular destinations. Buses, vans and private transfers handle the final stages. The mistake is looking only at the headline journey time.

A one-hour flight still involves getting to the airport, arriving early, checking in, flying, collecting luggage and reaching your hotel. A two-hour ferry can consume half a day once you include port transfers and waiting.

This is why a Philippines itinerary should be built around **travel days as much as destination days**.

FERRIES

Ferries can be an excellent way to move between islands, but don't assume every service operates exactly as scheduled. Weather, sea conditions and operational changes can affect services.

If you're travelling on an important connection, check the latest schedule and conditions. Avoid connecting a ferry directly into an international flight whenever possible.



SCOOTERS

Scooters are common across the Philippines, particularly in island destinations. They can be useful for exploring independently, but they are not suitable for everyone. Road conditions vary. Traffic can be unpredictable. Rain can arrive quickly.

If you ride, make sure you have the correct licence, appropriate insurance and genuine riding experience. If you don't, hire a driver or use local transport.

DIVING & WATER ACTIVITIES

The Philippines is one of the world's major diving and marine destinations. If you're planning diving, snorkelling, freediving, surfing, canyoning or other activities, check that your insurance actually covers them.

For diving in particular, choose a reputable operator and don't make price the only factor.

TRAVEL INSURANCE

Your policy should reflect the actual trip you're taking. Island-hopping, diving and motorbike travel can introduce exclusions that aren't obvious from the headline policy. Read the activity exclusions before you leave.

WHAT TO PACK

Travel light. You are likely to use airports, ferries, vans and boats repeatedly. A huge suitcase becomes annoying very quickly. Bring lightweight clothes, swimwear, comfortable shoes, sun protection and a waterproof bag or dry bag for boat trips. If you're staying in hostels or travelling independently, a compact backpack can be much easier than hard luggage.

CASH & REMOTE ISLANDS

Don't assume that every island has reliable banking infrastructure. Before heading somewhere remote, withdraw enough cash for several days.

This is particularly important if your accommodation, diving operator or transport provider does not accept cards.

THE BIGGEST PRE-TRIP MISTAKE

The biggest mistake is booking every domestic flight and hotel before understanding how the route connects. Book your international flights. Choose the regions. Check the important domestic flights and ferries. Then build the accommodation around those connections.

OUTBOUND TIP: In the Philippines, flexibility isn't a luxury.

It is part of good route planning.

03 — BUILD YOUR ROUTE

The Philippines is one of the countries where **route planning matters more than almost anywhere else in Southeast Asia**.

There are simply too many islands. Start by choosing your **core experience**.



PALAWAN

Choose Palawan if you want: **limestone islands, lagoons, beaches, snorkelling and dramatic scenery**. The two most obvious bases are **El Nido and Coron**.

They are both excellent, but they aren't interchangeable.

CEBU

Choose Cebu if you want: **diving, waterfalls, canyoneering and easy access to surrounding islands**. Cebu can be a useful transport hub as well as a destination.

BOHOL

Choose Bohol if you want: **beaches, countryside, the Chocolate Hills and a relatively easy island experience**. Panglao provides the main tourist infrastructure.

SIARGAO

Choose Siargao if you want: **surfing, island life, cafés and a slower tropical atmosphere**. You don't need to surf to enjoy it, but surfing is a major part of the island's identity.

BORACAY

Choose Boracay if you want: **a straightforward beach holiday with excellent infrastructure, restaurants and nightlife**. It is more developed than many other Philippine islands. That isn't necessarily a bad thing.

HOW MANY BASES?

Trip length	Recommended major bases	OUTBOUND approach
5–7 days	1–2	Choose one region
8–10 days	2–3	Two major experiences
11–14 days	3–4	Classic Philippines
15–21 days	4–5	Add another island selectively
3+ weeks	5+	Slow regional travel

The numbers are deliberately conservative. You *can* fit more in. The question is whether you should.

THE THREE-NIGHT RULE

Three nights is a useful starting point for most destinations. Two nights can work when the destination is compact or part of a logical route. One night is usually a warning sign. If you're flying or taking a ferry to an island for one night, ask whether the journey is worth it.

PALAWAN: EL NIDO OR CORON?

This is one of the biggest decisions.

El Nido is the stronger choice if you want dramatic lagoons, limestone cliffs, beaches and classic island-hopping.

Coron is particularly strong for diving, wrecks, lagoons and rugged scenery.



You can do both. But if you only have ten days, choosing one can make the trip considerably easier.

CEBU OR BOHOL?

Cebu makes more sense if adventure and diving are the priority. Bohol is the easier all-rounder for beaches, countryside and a slower pace. You can combine them, but don't assume you need both.

SIARGAO OR PALAWAN?

If your dream Philippines trip is **postcard beaches and lagoons**, choose Palawan. If your dream is **surf, cafés, island life and staying somewhere for a while**, choose Siargao.

THINK IN CONTRASTS

A strong route should change the experience. For example:

Manila → Palawan → Cebu

gives you:

city → islands → adventure.

Cebu → Bohol → Siargao

gives you:

adventure → beaches → slow island life.

El Nido → Coron

gives you:

lagoons → diving and rugged island scenery.

THE TRANSFER TEST

Before adding another island, ask: **How long will this move actually take?** Not the flight or ferry duration. The complete journey.

Hotel → transfer → airport/port → waiting → flight/ferry → baggage → transfer → hotel.

If you're losing most of a day, that destination needs to earn its place.

OUTBOUND RULE: The Philippines isn't about seeing as many islands as possible.

It's about choosing the islands that give you the **best combination of experiences**.

04 — PALAWAN

Palawan is where many travellers find the Philippines they imagined before arriving.



Turquoise water, limestone cliffs, hidden lagoons, beaches and boat trips create some of the country's most recognisable scenery. But even within Palawan, you still have to choose how you want to travel.

The classic decision is **El Nido versus Coron**.

EL NIDO

El Nido is one of the strongest choices for a first Philippines trip. The surrounding Bacuit Archipelago is famous for limestone formations, lagoons, beaches and island-hopping. The town itself is busy and highly developed for tourism. That's part of the convenience. It also means it won't feel like a completely untouched island.

ISLAND-HOPPING

Island-hopping is the main reason to come. Rather than trying to visit every beach individually, organised boat trips allow you to experience multiple islands and lagoons in a single day. The exact tours and routes vary, so choose based on what you actually want to see rather than simply selecting the tour with the biggest letter or number. If you're travelling with friends, a private boat can sometimes be worth considering. It gives you more control over departure times and stops.

HOW LONG?

Three or four nights is a strong starting point. Two nights can work, but the journey to El Nido makes a very short stay feel rushed. Five nights gives you more flexibility and allows a slower day between boat trips.

CORON

Coron has a different character. It is particularly famous for **wreck diving, lagoons, lakes and rugged island scenery**. If diving is a major reason you're visiting the Philippines, Coron deserves serious consideration. Even if you don't dive, the island-hopping and scenery can make it worthwhile.

CORON DIVING

The Japanese shipwrecks around Coron are a major attraction for experienced divers. If wreck diving is something you've always wanted to do, this may be the destination that determines your entire Philippines route. Choose a reputable dive operator and make sure the experience matches your certification and experience.

EL NIDO OR CORON?

Choose El Nido for classic island-hopping, lagoons and beaches. **Choose Coron** for diving, wrecks, lagoons and a more rugged experience. If you have enough time, combine them. But don't assume that doing both is mandatory.

EL NIDO + CORON

A longer Palawan route can work extremely well. Spend three or four nights in El Nido. Then travel onwards to Coron using an appropriate connection. Give yourself enough time in both destinations to make the transfer worthwhile. Don't schedule the most important activity immediately after the transfer.

THE PALAWAN MISTAKE

The biggest mistake is spending the entire trip chasing beaches. The boat journey itself is part of the experience. Slow down. Swim. Snorkel. Eat. Watch the sunset. Let the landscape do some of the work.



OUTBOUND VERDICT: If someone told you to visit only one region of the Philippines for your first trip, **Palawan** would be one of the strongest answers.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't rush through Palawan to say you've done El Nido *and* Coron. One properly experienced island group is better than two rushed ones.

05 — CEBU & BOHOL

Cebu and Bohol work well together because they provide a useful combination of **adventure, beaches and easier island travel**. But again, you don't necessarily need both.

CEBU

Cebu is one of the Philippines' major travel hubs. The island and surrounding region offer diving, waterfalls, beaches and access to nearby destinations. It can therefore work as both a destination and a logistical base.

MOALBOAL

Moalboal is one of the strongest places to visit around Cebu if marine life is important to you. The famous **sardine run** is one of the area's defining experiences. You don't need to spend a week there. Two or three nights can be enough for most travellers.

KAWASAN FALLS

Kawasan Falls and the surrounding canyoneering experience are another major reason travellers head south. If you're doing canyoneering, treat it as a proper adventure activity. Use a reputable operator and follow safety instructions. Don't schedule a complicated transfer immediately afterwards if you can avoid it.

OSLOB

Oslob is famous for whale shark tourism. This is one area where you should think carefully about the **wildlife experience**, not simply whether something is popular. Research the current conditions, operator practices and conservation concerns before deciding whether to participate. Don't choose an experience purely because it guarantees a photograph.

BOHOL

Bohol provides a slower alternative. The island combines beaches, countryside, the Chocolate Hills and other natural attractions. **Panglao** is the obvious base for most travellers because of its accommodation, restaurants and access to beaches and activities.

CHOCOLATE HILLS

The Chocolate Hills are one of Bohol's defining landscapes. They are worth seeing if you're interested in the island's geography and scenery. Don't build an entire day around a single viewpoint, though. Combine them with other inland experiences.

PANGLAO

Panglao is where you can slow down. Use it for beaches, diving, snorkelling, restaurants and recovery time. This makes Bohol particularly useful after a more activity-heavy section of a trip.



CEBU OR BOHOL?

Choose **Cebu** if adventure and diving are the priority. Choose **Bohol** if you want a more balanced mixture of beaches, scenery and relaxation. Choose both if you have enough time and the experiences genuinely interest you.

THE COMBINATION

A strong route might be:

Days 1–3 — Cebu/Moalboal: Adventure and marine life.

Days 4–6 — Bohol: Beaches, countryside and a slower pace.

Day 7 onwards — another region: This creates a natural progression.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Cebu is about **doing**. Bohol is about **experiencing at a slower pace**.

06 — SIARGAO

Siargao is different. The island has become famous for surfing, but its appeal goes beyond the waves. It has developed a strong café, restaurant and social scene while retaining the feeling of a tropical island where you can stay in one place for several days and settle into a routine.

HOW LONG?

Give Siargao **four to five nights** if you have the time. Three nights can work. But this is exactly the kind of destination where staying longer often makes the trip better.

SURFING

Cloud 9 is the island's most famous surf area. Experienced surfers will have plenty to explore, while beginners can look for lessons and more suitable breaks. You don't have to surf to visit Siargao. But if surfing is something you want to learn, the island becomes a much stronger choice.

GENERAL LUNA

General Luna is the main tourist hub. It has restaurants, cafés, bars, surf schools, accommodation and easy access to tours. It can be social and busy. That may be exactly what you want. If you're looking for total isolation, stay further away.

ISLAND-HOPPING

Trips around **Naked Island, Daku Island and Guyam Island** are among the classic Siargao experiences. The appeal isn't necessarily spending hours at each island. It's the combination of boat travel, swimming, beaches and a relaxed day away from General Luna.

SUGBA LAGOON

Sugba Lagoon provides a different experience, with dramatic scenery and opportunities for swimming and water activities. Again, don't try to do everything in one day.



MAGPUPUNGKO

Magpupungko Rock Pools are another popular natural attraction, with access dependent on tidal conditions. Check the tide before planning your day.

MOTORBIKES

A scooter can be a useful way to explore Siargao. But the same rules apply as elsewhere in the Philippines. Ride only if you're properly licensed, insured and experienced.

THE SIARGAO RHYTHM

Siargao is best when you don't over-plan it. Surf in the morning. Eat lunch. Explore the island. Swim. Watch sunset. Have dinner. Go out if you want. Repeat. That is the point.

SIARGAO OR PALAWAN?

Choose **Palawan** for dramatic scenery and classic island-hopping. Choose **Siargao** for surf, social atmosphere and slower island life. If you have three weeks, you can absolutely do both. If you have ten days, choosing one may be the better holiday.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Siargao isn't somewhere you need to conquer. It's somewhere you **settle into**.

OUTBOUND RULE: If your itinerary has four activities scheduled every day in Siargao, you've missed the point.

07 — BORACAY & OTHER ISLANDS

Boracay is the Philippines' easiest answer to the question: **“Where should I go if I just want a great beach holiday?”** The island is developed, accessible and built around tourism.

That means plenty of accommodation, restaurants, activities and nightlife. It also means it is not the place to go if your definition of paradise is an empty island with nobody else around.

BORACAY

The island is famous for **White Beach**, with its long stretch of pale sand and clear water. It is beautiful. It is also popular. The trick is deciding what kind of Boracay trip you want. If you want nightlife, restaurants and easy access to everything, stay around the busier parts of White Beach. If you want something quieter, choose your accommodation more carefully.

HOW LONG?

Three nights is enough for most travellers. Four or five works if you're treating Boracay as the main beach holiday. There is little need to rush around the island.

WHAT TO DO

The best Boracay experience can be surprisingly simple. Swim. Walk the beach. Try watersports. Take a boat trip. Eat. Watch the sunset. Go out at night. Repeat. Don't feel pressure to fill every hour.

BORACAY OR PALAWAN?



This is one of the most useful decisions in the Philippines. **Choose Boracay** if you want convenience, nightlife, restaurants and a straightforward beach holiday. **Choose Palawan** if you want dramatic scenery, island-hopping and a more adventurous experience.

OTHER ISLAND OPTIONS

The Philippines has far more islands than can fit into one guide. That is precisely why you should be selective. **Camiguin** can appeal to travellers looking for a quieter, more off-the-beaten-path island experience. **Siquijor** is attractive for travellers who want beaches, waterfalls and a slower island atmosphere. **Apo Island** is particularly interesting for marine life and diving. **Bantayan** offers a more relaxed beach experience away from the biggest tourist centres.

These aren't necessarily additions to your first itinerary. They are alternatives.

THE OUTBOUND TEST

If you're already visiting Palawan and Siargao, ask whether adding Boracay actually improves the trip. If the answer is "it has a famous beach", that may not be enough. If your dream is specifically a comfortable beach resort with nightlife and easy infrastructure, then it absolutely may be worth it.

OUTBOUND RULE: Famous doesn't automatically mean necessary.

Choose the island that gives you the **experience you're missing**, not another version of something you've already done.

08 — GETTING AROUND THE PHILIPPINES

Transport is the part of a Philippines trip that can make or break the itinerary. The country is enormous and fragmented across islands, so **flights and ferries are not optional details**. They are part of the route.

DOMESTIC FLIGHTS

Flying is often the most practical way to cover large distances. If you have ten days, don't spend an entire day travelling overland and by ferry simply because the alternative flight costs slightly more. Your holiday time has value. Domestic flights are particularly useful when connecting major islands or avoiding long surface journeys.

FERRIES

Ferries make sense when destinations are naturally connected. They can also be enjoyable. But don't assume a ferry journey is automatically better simply because it looks shorter on the map.

Check:

departure point → check-in time → ferry → arrival → onward transfer.

That is the real journey.

BUSES & VANS

Shared vans and buses are common, particularly on larger islands. They can be cheap but journey times can be unpredictable. Don't build a critical connection around an optimistic road journey estimate.



PRIVATE TRANSFERS

For groups, private transfers can be surprisingly good value. They are particularly useful when travelling between airports, ports and accommodation. Confirm exactly what is included before booking.

SCOOTERS

Scooters are useful for exploring smaller islands. They are not essential. If you don't have the correct licence, experience and insurance, don't ride.

FLIGHT + FERRY CONNECTIONS

This is one of the most common Philippines travel patterns.

For example:

flight → airport transfer → port → ferry → hotel.

It can work extremely well. It can also consume an entire day. Don't book an expensive activity immediately after a complicated connection.

WEATHER BUFFER

This matters more in the Philippines than in many other Southeast Asian countries. Weather can affect flights and ferries. If your international flight leaves on Saturday, don't build an itinerary that requires you to make a complicated island transfer on Saturday morning.

Get back towards your departure airport earlier.

LUGGAGE

Keep luggage manageable. Boats and small transfers become considerably easier when you're carrying a backpack rather than a giant suitcase. Protect electronics from water when travelling by boat. A small dry bag can be extremely useful.

BOOKING

Book important domestic flights when your route is confirmed. For ferries, check the current timetable rather than assuming an old schedule is still valid. Popular activities such as diving and island-hopping can also be worth reserving ahead during busy periods.

THE TRANSPORT DAY

Don't call something a "two-hour ferry" and assume it takes two hours.

Your actual day may be:

8:00 — hotel departure.

9:00 — arrive at port.

10:00 — ferry.



12:00 — arrive.

13:00 — transfer.

14:00 — hotel.

That's six hours. Count six hours.

OUTBOUND TIP: In the Philippines, paying slightly more for a flight can sometimes buy you an entire extra day of holiday.

That can be excellent value.

09 — THE ROUTES

The Philippines is too geographically complicated for one perfect itinerary.

The routes below are designed around **arrival and departure days**.

So:

7 days = usually 6 nights.

10 days = usually 9 nights.

14 days = usually 13 nights.

21 days = usually 20 nights.

The most important rule is to choose the route **before** booking all your hotels.

7 DAYS — PICK ONE REGION

Seven days is short. Don't fight that.

OPTION A — PALAWAN

Days 1–3 — El Nido

Three nights.

Island-hopping, lagoons and beaches.

Days 4–6 — El Nido

Continue exploring or use the time for a slower beach day.

Day 7 — Departure



This is the simplest option. If your priority is seeing the Philippines' famous scenery, it works extremely well.

OPTION B — CEBU + BOHOL

Days 1–3 — Cebu/Moalboal

Marine life, waterfalls and adventure.

Days 4–6 — Bohol

Beaches, countryside and the Chocolate Hills.

Day 7 — Departure

A strong option for travellers who want variety without crossing the entire country.

OPTION C — SIARGAO

Spend the entire week around Siargao. This is genuinely a good option. Surf. Explore. Island-hop. Relax. You don't need another island.

WHAT NOT TO DO

Manila → El Nido → Coron → Cebu → Bohol → Siargao in seven days.

The itinerary exists. The holiday doesn't.

10 DAYS — TWO EXPERIENCES

Ten days gives you enough time to combine two major regions.

OPTION A — PALAWAN

Days 1–4 — El Nido

Four nights.

Days 5–8 — Coron

Four nights.

Day 9 — Buffer / return

Day 10 — Departure

This is one of the strongest routes if Palawan is your priority. You get the classic El Nido experience followed by Coron.

OPTION B — CEBU + BOHOL + SIARGAO

Days 1–3 — Cebu



Three nights.

Days 4–6 — Bohol

Three nights.

Days 7–9 — Siargao

Three nights.

Day 10 — Departure

This is more ambitious because of the transport involved, but it can work if the connections line up.

OPTION C — BORACAY + CEBU

Days 1–4 — Boracay

Four nights.

Days 5–9 — Cebu

Five nights, including the possibility of Moalboal and other activities.

Day 10 — Departure

Good for travellers who want **beach + adventure**.

OUTBOUND VERDICT

At ten days, I would generally choose: **Palawan** if scenery is the priority. **Cebu + Bohol** if you want variety. **Siargao** if island life is the priority.

14 DAYS — THE CLASSIC PHILIPPINES TRIP

Two weeks gives you considerably more freedom.

OPTION A — MANILA + PALAWAN + CEBU

Days 1–2 — Manila

Two nights. Use Manila as an introduction rather than trying to see everything.

Days 3–6 — El Nido

Four nights.

Days 7–9 — Coron

Three nights.

**Days 10–13 — Cebu**

Four nights.

Day 14 — Departure

This is a strong first-time route if you want **city + Palawan + adventure**.

OPTION B — CEBU + BOHOL + SIARGAO**Days 1–4 — Cebu**

Four nights.

Days 5–8 — Bohol

Four nights.

Days 9–13 — Siargao

Five nights.

Day 14 — Departure

This is better for travellers who want a more relaxed island-focused trip.

OPTION C — BORACAY + PALAWAN**Days 1–4 — Boracay**

Four nights.

Days 5–9 — El Nido

Five nights.

Days 10–13 — Coron

Four nights.

Day 14 — Departure

This is the beach-heavy option. It gives you a combination of:

easy beach holiday → dramatic island scenery → diving/adventure.

OPTION D — SIARGAO + BOHOL + CEBU

Four nights Siargao. Four nights Bohol. Five nights Cebu. Day 14 departure.

This is the strongest choice if you want **surf + beaches + adventure**.



21 DAYS — THE FULL EXPERIENCE

Three weeks gives you enough time to combine several regions without every transfer becoming a crisis.

A strong route could be:

DAYS 1–3 — MANILA

Three nights.

Use the time to arrive, adjust and explore the city.

DAYS 4–7 — EL NIDO

Four nights.

Island-hopping and beaches.

DAYS 8–10 — CORON

Three nights.

Diving, lagoons and island scenery.

DAYS 11–14 — CEBU

Four nights.

Moalboal, waterfalls and marine experiences.

DAYS 15–18 — BOHOL

Four nights.

Beaches, countryside and the Chocolate Hills.

DAYS 19–20 — SIARGAO

Two nights.

A very short stay, so this is the first section I would cut if the connections become inconvenient.

DAY 21 — DEPARTURE

A better alternative would actually be to **drop Siargao and give the extra days to Bohol, Cebu or Palawan**. That's the OUTBOUND approach. Three weeks doesn't mean you need six destinations.

THE BETTER 21-DAY VERSION

Days 1–3 — Manila

Days 4–8 — El Nido



Days 9–12 — Coron

Days 13–16 — Cebu

Days 17–20 — Bohol

Day 21 — Departure

This is slower and much easier to execute.

You get:

city → lagoons → diving → adventure → beaches.

If surfing is one of your top priorities, replace part of the route with Siargao.

WHICH ROUTE IS RIGHT FOR YOU?

If you want **the classic postcard Philippines**, choose: **El Nido + Coron**.

If you want **adventure and diving**, choose: **Cebu + Coron**.

If you want **surf and island life**, choose: **Siargao**.

If you want **easy beaches and nightlife**, choose: **Boracay**.

If you want **a balanced island trip**, choose: **Cebu + Bohol**.

If you want the **widest first-time experience**, consider: **Manila → Palawan → Cebu/Bohol**.

And if you have three weeks, resist the temptation to turn it into a six-island tour. The Philippines is one of the few countries where **doing less can genuinely mean seeing more**. Every island you remove gives you more time to swim, eat, explore and actually remember where you are.

OUTBOUND RULE: If an itinerary contains more ferry terminals than beach days, start deleting destinations.

10 — YOUR FINAL PHILIPPINES CHECKLIST

The Philippines is one of the easiest countries to build an unrealistic itinerary for. Your final job is making sure the route works **in real life**.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Decide what you want. **Beaches? Surfing? Diving? Island-hopping? Wildlife? Adventure? Nightlife? Slow island life?** Pick your priorities. Then choose the islands that deliver them. Don't choose islands first and figure out what to do there afterwards.



CHECK THE WEATHER

Look at the conditions for the **specific islands** you're visiting. Don't assume the entire country has identical weather. If you're travelling during wetter periods, build flexibility into ferry and flight connections.

BUILD THE ROUTE FIRST

Choose the regions. Check the flights. Check the ferries. Check the road transfers. Then book the accommodation. Don't do it in reverse.

YOUR TRANSFERS

Write down every major journey.

Include:

Hotel → airport. Airport → flight. Flight → baggage. Baggage → transfer. Transfer → port. Port → ferry. Ferry → hotel.

That is the real travel time. If the total is six hours, count six hours.

YOUR THREE NON-NEGOTIABLES

Pick the **three experiences you absolutely want**.

For example: **Island-hopping around El Nido. Diving in Coron. Watching the sunset in Siargao.**

Or:

Canyoneering in Cebu. Chocolate Hills in Bohol. A week on the beach.

Your three experiences should shape the route.

YOUR TRANSPORT

Book important domestic flights once the route is confirmed. Check current ferry schedules. Leave buffers around important connections. Never make your international departure dependent on a same-day ferry.

YOUR MONEY

Carry cash when travelling to smaller islands. Don't assume every business accepts cards.

Budget separately for: **flights, ferries, accommodation, activities and food.**

The Philippines can be cheap, but island-hopping and diving can increase costs quickly.

YOUR ACTIVITIES

Book genuinely important activities ahead where necessary. For diving, use reputable operators. For adventure activities, prioritise safety. For wildlife experiences, research the operator and conservation practices.

Don't let Instagram determine what you do.



YOUR PACKING

Keep luggage light.

Bring:

Light clothing.

Swimwear.

Comfortable shoes.

Sun protection.

A small dry bag.

Waterproof protection for electronics.

A lightweight rain layer.

Something warm enough for air-conditioned transport if needed.

YOUR SCOOTER

If you're riding, make sure:

You have the correct licence. Your insurance covers you. You are genuinely comfortable riding. You understand the local road conditions. If not, don't ride.

THE FINAL TEST

Look at the entire itinerary.

Ask:

Am I excited about every major destination?

Have I allowed enough time in each place?

Are the transfers realistic?

Have I checked the weather for my route?

Have I left enough buffer around flights and ferries?

Are my three biggest experiences protected?

Does this actually feel like a holiday?

If the answer is no:

Remove something.



The Philippines will still be there. You don't need to see every island. You don't need to visit every famous beach. You don't need to take every recommended tour. You need to build a trip where the **journeys are worth the destinations**. The best Philippines itinerary isn't the one with the longest list. It's the one where you have enough time to remember the places you went. The boat ride through turquoise water. The first dive. The sunset over the palms. The tiny restaurant you found by accident. The scooter ride through the countryside. The beach you didn't want to leave. The morning when you realised you had nowhere else to be.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't spend your Philippines holiday trying to see the whole country. **Pick the islands you care about. Stay longer. Enjoy them properly.**

OUTBOUND

Fewer islands. Better trips.